continue to chronicle the character's adventures in a series of movies). When he reaches the water's edge, he can run no further. The final, frozen moment as he turns back seems to say that, far from having escaped, he will remain forever captured. The impression it makes is one of hope mixed with defeat.

## Escape to the movies

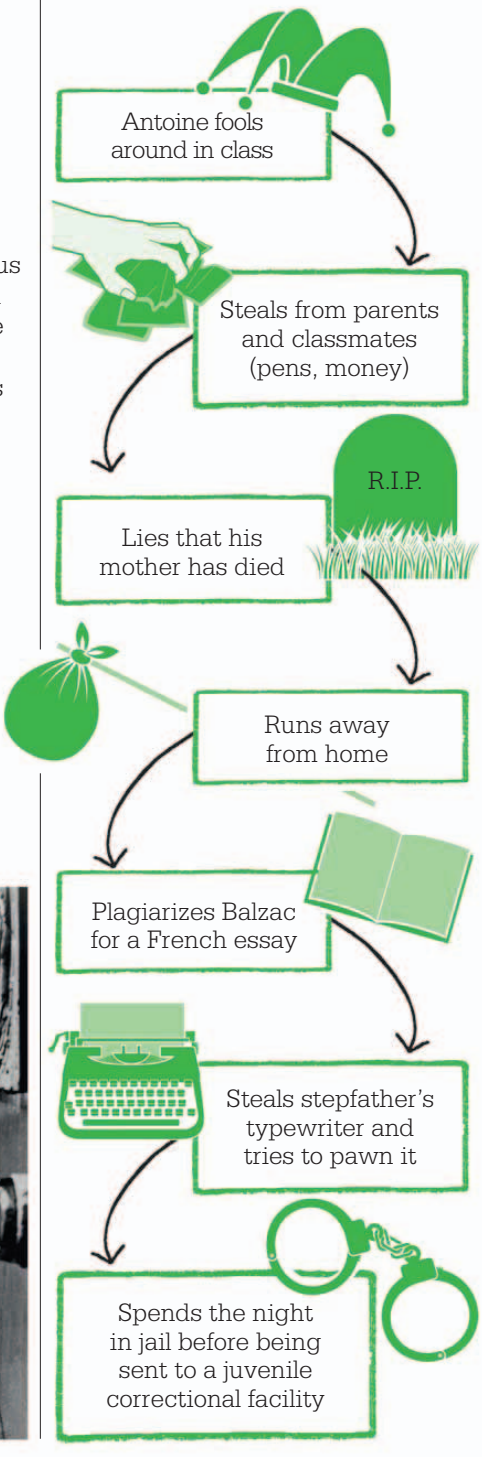
Antoine finds another means of escape: the movies. He slips into a movie theater whenever he can, to lose himself in the dark of the theater's seats and the images on the screen, much as the young Truffaut himself did.

It is here that the character's life crosses irresistibly into the life of his creator. There is the constant sense that the director is trying to explore or exorcise his own past, redefining it with shots and scenes borrowed wholesale from other movies, such as *Zero de Conduite* (1933, pp.50–51) and *Little Fugitive* (1953), in the same way that Antoine borrows from Balzac to make sense of himself. It's not just a passion for the movies that Antoine and Truffaut have in common. Antoine doesn't know who his biological father is, and he lives with a distant stepfather, just as the director did in his youth. Antoine runs away from home, as Truffaut did when he was eleven. Antoine tries to convince his teacher that his mother has died (one of his outrageous lies). The young Truffaut claimed that his father had been arrested by the Germans.

All movies comprise outrageous lies, and conjure worlds of illusion and pretense populated by people acting as someone they are not. But Truffaut's debut movie proves that, when arranged for a certain purpose and related with heart, lies can reveal and illuminate the truth in a way that the bare facts cannot. It was this truth, as well as the promise of escape, that excited those French filmmakers who dipped their toes into the New Wave. ■

**After Antoine sets fire** to his shrine to Balzac, his favorite author, his stepfather threatens to send him to a military academy.

***The 400 Blows* charts** Antoine's descent into delinquency, from classroom jokes to imprisonment, as the adult world rejects him.

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